

PROJECT The one-hour process audit	DRAWN BY Caleb Bolden • calebbolden.com	SHEET audit 01	REV A
---------------------------------------	---	-------------------	----------

Map one workflow, find the waste, know what to fix first.

One hour, one process, pen and paper. Most software projects fail for people and process reasons, not technical ones; analysts who study failed CRM rollouts put over 60% of the blame on adoption and process problems, and under 10% on the platform itself. The fix is boring and it works: understand the process before you buy anything for it. This worksheet is the same first hour I spend with consulting clients. Do it honestly and you will know more about your own business by lunch.

1 Pick your process

5 MIN

Pick ONE workflow, not your whole business. Good candidates: the one that generates the most complaints, the one only you know how to do, or the one that touches money (quotes, invoices, collections).

Process name: _____

How often it runs (per week): _____ What triggers it (a call? a form? a sale?): _____

Why it hurts (one sentence): _____

What "done" looks like: _____

2 Walk the steps

15 MIN

List every step from trigger to done. Aim for 4 to 10 steps; more than 10 means you are listing sub-steps, zoom out. The last column matters most: in most office processes the work itself is fast, and the waiting between steps is where days disappear. When the table is full, **circle** every step where the same information gets typed again into a different system, and **star** the single longest wait.

#	STEP	WHO DOES IT	TOOL OR SYSTEM	HOW LONG IT WAITS BEFORE PICKUP
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				
7				
8				

3 The waste checklist

15 MIN

Go through these eight questions about the process you just mapped. Check every yes.

- ☐ **Redoing:** Do you regularly fix data-entry mistakes or redo paperwork in this process?
- ☐ **Too early:** Does anything get prepared, printed, or processed before it is actually needed?
- ☐ **Waiting:** Does work sit in an inbox or queue waiting on an approval or a reply?
- ☐ **Wasted skill:** Does your most skilled person spend time here on something anyone could do?
- ☐ **Hand-offs:** Does information pass through people or systems it does not need to?
- ☐ **Backlog:** Is there a pile of unprocessed files, unread messages, or unbilled work in this process?
- ☐ **Re-entry:** Do people re-type the same data, bounce between apps, or hunt for information?
- ☐ **Rubber stamps:** Are there approvals or checks in this process that never actually change anything?

Checks: _____ / 8. Three or more on one process is normal and fixable. Waiting and hand-off problems are usually process fixes (free); re-entry and backlog problems are usually automation fixes (cheap); wasted-skill problems are usually delegation fixes (a decision).

4 What it really costs

15 MIN

Owners guess badly about time. Measure one task inside this process instead.

Task: _____

Time it 3 to 5 times (minutes, note interruptions): _____

Average minutes: _____ Times per week: _____ **Weekly hours on this one task:** _____

Multiply weekly hours by what an hour of that person's time costs you. That number is the budget you can justify spending to fix it, every single month.

5 The one thing

10 MIN

Your star (longest wait), circles (double data entry), and checkboxes (wastes) usually point at the same one or two spots. Write it down.

The bottleneck: _____

Why it happens (ask "why" up to five times until you hit a process gap, not a person):

The fix type (circle one): **process change** · **automation** · **delegation**

That is your starting point. Not an AI strategy, not a new platform. One process, one bottleneck, one fix, measured by the weekly-hours number from step 4.

Want a second opinion?

Send me a photo or scan of your completed worksheet and I will reply with what I would fix first and roughly what it should cost. Free, 20 minutes of my time, no obligation.

calebbolden.com/contact

Caleb Bolden is an AI consultant for local small businesses. Before AI, he did lean and six sigma process work. This worksheet is the lightweight version of the value stream mapping those disciplines use on factory floors, adapted for offices, shops, and service businesses.